governance and persistence of unequal land holding patterns. The migration wave had given India its first President in Rajendra Prasad (1884–1963) and the activist Jayaprakash Narayan (1902–79) whose political movement defiantly opposed the Emergency imposed in the 1970s. But apart from this, it had little to celebrate as circular migrations rarely eased the pressure on the land and, in fact, sustained it. For Saran, its density, it would appear, was its destiny.

Cyclone Psychology: Ganjam in Odisha

In the middle of the 19th century, Henry Piddington (1797–1858), an English merchant who eventually settled in India, coined a new word—cyclone—to describe the peculiar pattern of circular wind movement witnessed during storms in the Bay of Bengal.[28] Having its roots in the Greek word ‘kukloma’, which meant a wheel or the coils of snakes, cyclones would cause intense damage and had a particular affinity for Ganjam district on India’s east coast. Here, they would arrive with great thunder in 1864, 1887, 1909, 1938, 1942, 1968, 1972, 1981, 1984, 1999 and 2013.[29] How does one eke out a livelihood when your house and crops are destroyed once in fifteen years?

The Ganjami response to circular wind movements since the late 19th century has been simple: circular migration. To be more precise, it was circular mass male migration as the district’s sex ratio rose from 970 females per 1000 males in 1872 to over 1100 in 1901 and hovered at that number for another six decades. The ‘missing men’ of Ganjam found a destination across the Bay of Bengal, long known to the people on India’s east coast as *suvarna bhumi* or land of gold.[30] Boarding a steamer from the district’s port of Gopalpur, they would head for Rangoon, the capital of Burma. Here, they would disembark and take up a multitude of occupations across lower Burma. Nearly half of them worked in the transport sector—railways, road and water—and another 15 per cent were engaged in rice pounding.[31] Burma had become the rice exporter of the world. Rice harvesting and processing operations required labour which the Ganjamis